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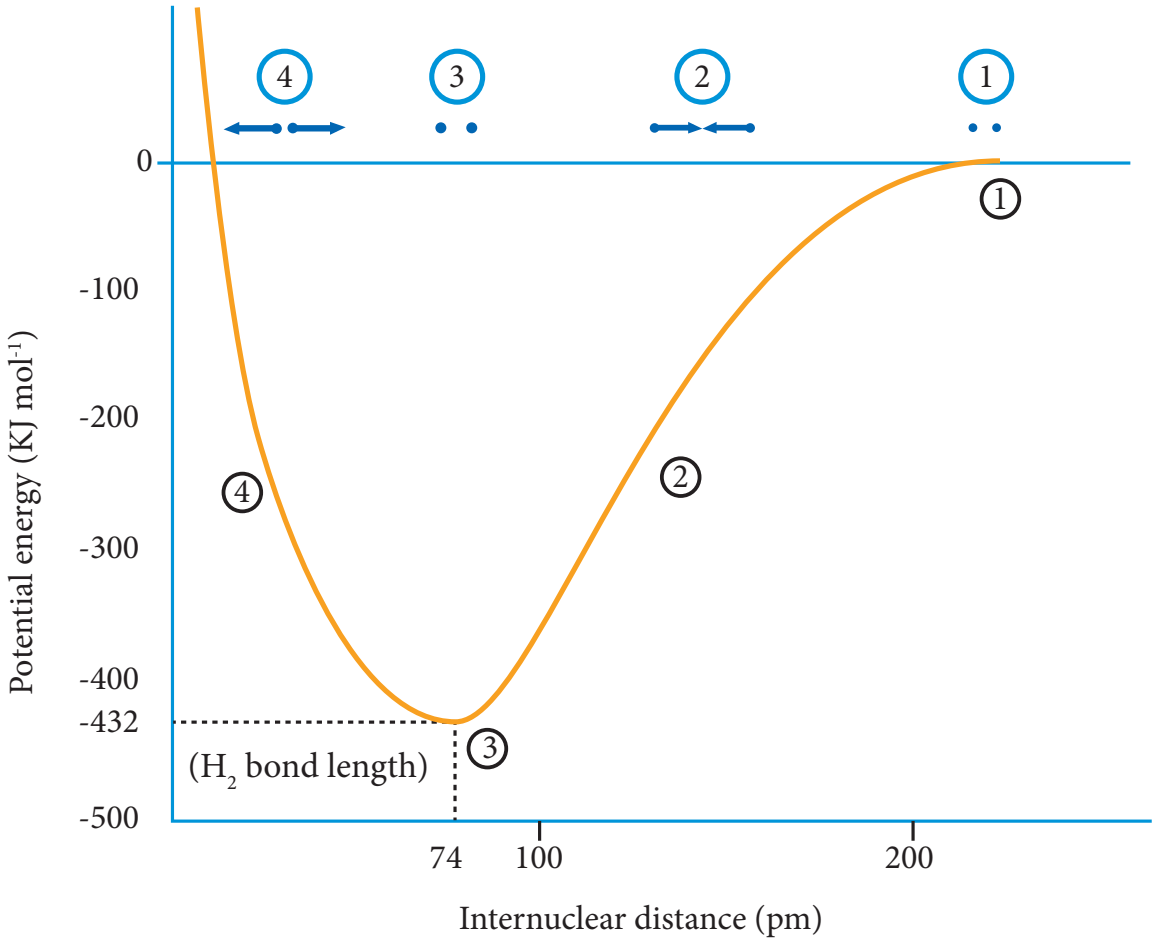

Fig 10. 17 (b) VB theory for the formation of hydrogen molecule

At this stage, there is a maximum overlap between the atomic orbitals of H_a and H_b, and the atoms H_a and H_b are now said to be bonded together by a covalent bond. The internuclear distance at this stage gives the H-H bond length and is equal to 74 pm. The liberated energy is 436 kJ mol^{-1} and is known as bond energy. Since the energy is released during the bond formation, the resultant molecule is more stable. If the distance between the two atoms is decreased further, the repulsive forces dominate the attractive forces and the potential energy of the system sharply increases

10.7.1 Salient features of VB Theory:

(i) When half filled orbitals of two atoms overlap, a covalent bond will be formed between them.

(ii) The resultant overlapping orbital is occupied by the two electrons with opposite spins. For example, when H_2 is formed, the two 1s electrons of two hydrogen atoms get paired up and occupy the overlapped orbital.

(iii) The strength of a covalent bond depends upon the extent of overlap of atomic orbitals. Greater the overlap, larger is the energy released and stronger will be the bond formed.